

PIVOT OR PERSIST: THE DECISION TREE

Keep Going vs Pivot — Decision Tree

What it is: Concrete thresholds for when to persist vs kill a niche — so you don't burn a year like Kevis did on self-improvement (monetized, ~\$2 RPM, ~\$1,000 in six months, first payday ~\$3).

When to use it: After video 7, video 14, first monetization check, or any week you feel “maybe I'm the problem.”

Doctrine: YouTube is a consistency + ideation game. Outliers exist. So do slow channels. The tree separates **execution problems** (fixable) from **niche / RPM problems** (pivot).

How to load this (1 page)

Claude

I'm on video __ in niche __. Here's Studio: impressions __, views __, RPM __, upload streak __. Walk the HeadStart pivot tree. Do not invent numbers.

Notion

Board: Persist | Fix packaging | Park | Pivot — with threshold properties.

Hard truths first

1. **Monetized ≠ good business.** Kevis's first channel proved it.
2. **1,000 views here and there can feel like progress and still be a trap.**
3. **Vanity niches with teen RPMs waste the only scarce resource: nights after work.**
4. **One viral then silence** is usually a **format** problem, not always a niche kill — see WWKD.
5. **Impressions matter before vanity views.** Teaching rule of thumb from HeadStart brief: after **~7 posts**, **~1k impressions** ≈ park signal; **~10k impressions** ≈ “alive.” Re-check on *your* niche comps — not gospel, but better than vibes.

Inputs you must have (no guessing)

Input	Where
Upload count & streak	Studio
Impressions (last 28d / per video)	Reach
Views + CTR + AVD	Studio
RPM / RPM estimated	Revenue (after YPP) or competitor teaching range only
Edit cost per video	Your invoices
Hours you personally spent / week	Honest calendar
Scorecard total at entry	Your sheet

If you don't have these, collect for 7 more days of clean uploads before pivoting on emotion.

The tree

Node 0 — Are you actually posting?

- < 7 long-form uploads → **PERSIST on process**. Fix Owner OS (ideas → script → \$30 editor → thumb → upload). Do not pivot yet.
- ≥ 7 uploads → Node 1.

Node 1 — Impression jail vs market response

Look at typical impressions after 48–72h on recent uploads:

Signal	Meaning	Action
Near-zero impressions repeatedly	Account / trust / packaging not entering auction	Fix: trusted account hygiene, title/thumb tests, don't burn niche yet (PERSIST + packaging)
~1k impressions after ~7 posts, flat	Weak distribution	PARK niche candidate; costume deeper or swap pattern
Growing impressions, low CTR	Packaging problem	PERSIST — iterate thumbs/titles (high leverage)
Healthy CTR, dying AVD	Script / format / promise mismatch	PERSIST — winning-format work, not niche kill
Healthy funnel, views OK, RPM terrible after YPP	Wrong demographic / vertical	PIVOT (this is the self-improvement lesson)

Node 2 — RPM gate (after monetization OR clear comps)

RPM reality	Action
Teaching-trap zone (~\$1–\$3) on mature effort	PIVOT — do not “scale a broken unit economy”
Mid (~\$4–\$7) with older demo unclear	Re-costume audience; check Suggested neighbors; BORDERLINE
Strong for your vertical (teaching often cites mature ~\$8–\$20, finance higher)	PERSIST — scale format engine

No Studio yet? Use scorecard A1–A3 + comps. Unknown → don’t assume high RPM.

Node 3 — Banger-to-flop ratio

Over last 10 uploads:

Pattern	Action
0 standouts, all flat	Check Node 1; if impressions exist → format research (bonus: Viral Format Finder later)
1 viral, 9 dead	PERSIST niche — extract winning format; do not chase new niches weekly
2–3 repeatable standouts	PERSIST — you have a format engine; hire for speed
Declining after early luck	Audience shift or packaging decay — diagnose before pivot

Node 4 — Time / second-job tax

Your week	Action
>4 hours/night editing or micromanaging	You built a job — outsource edit; keep judgment only
≤15–30 min/day on thumbs + upload + light QA	Owner OS healthy — judge niche on data, not fatigue
Inconsistent uploads (<3/week when plan was daily/near-daily)	Fix ops before blaming niche

Node 5 — Calendar stop-loss

Investment	Rule
14 clean uploads in a PASS-scorecard niche with impressions still dead after packaging tests	PARK / PIVOT
30–45 days monetized with trap RPM	PIVOT (don’t wait 6–12 months)
90 days daily posting, mid results, good RPM	PERSIST — compound (Rick shows both outlier boards and slow \$2.8k/90d boards — both real)

Flowchart (text)

```
POSTING < 7? —yes→ PERSIST (ops)
| no
IMPRESSIONS dead? —yes→ PERSIST packaging / account (not niche yet)
| no
CTR bad? —yes→ PERSIST thumbs/titles
| no
```

```
AVD bad? —yes→ PERSIST script/format
| no
RPM trap / young demo? —yes→ PIVOT niche
| no
1 viral then silence? —yes→ PERSIST niche; fix FORMAT
| no
Second-job hours? —yes→ Fix OS; re-enter tree next week
| no
PERSIST + scale winning format
```

Worked scenarios

A. Self-improvement year (Kevis)

Monetized, ~\$2 RPM, drip views → **PIVOT** at Node 2. Lesson: pass scorecard *before* loyalty.

B. Viral once, then silence

Node 3 → **PERSIST niche**, hunt winning format (cross-niche arbitrage). See `05-what-would-kevis-do.md`.

C. Canadian family ~\$4 RPM, short videos (consultation tape)

Not automatic pivot — session-time / product / length constraints. Diagnose inventory before niche kill.

D. 90 days daily, \$2.8k (Rick teaching contrast)

If RPM OK → **PERSIST**; if RPM trap → pivot even if “consistent.”

Pivot checklist (when tree says PIVOT)

1. Freeze editor spend on old niche.
 2. Re-run costume 3 days (`03`).
 3. Score 3 new candidates (`02`).
 4. Prefer adjacent psychographics if you already have a winning format.
 5. Plan new first 10 (`05`).
 6. Write one sentence: *why the old niche failed the unit economy* — so you don’t re-enter it in three months.
-

Persist checklist

1. Double down on the **format** that worked.
 2. Keep Owner OS: you = niche/ideas/packaging; editor = cuts.
 3. Re-score monthly — markets rot.
 4. Ignore guru “post until it works” without RPM math.
-